

EYEWITNESS May, 1954

Dien Bien Phu

The Viet Minh siege of the French Expeditionary Force at Dien Bien Phu lasted from March 13 to May 7, 1954. The conditions within the besieged base, where shallow trenches provided little protection against constant enemy artillery fire, demanded exceptional powers of endurance. French doctor Major Paul-Henri Grauwin, head of the mobile surgical unit at Dien Bien Phu, tended to the injured and dying during the final week of the siege.

In his account he describes the relentless harassment of the French Expeditionary Force by the Viet Minh artillery—one attack following another, almost without stopping. The Viet Minh were taking hold of trenches in the north, one yard at a time, and the French were waiting for the final onslaught to take place.

During the final week of the siege, it rained all day with no respite and the passages were full of stretchers the entire time. Meanwhile, more wounded soldiers waited outside, under fire, in the pouring rain and the mud. The Viet Minh suddenly increased their numbers tenfold until they were everywhere. Rising out of the mud and water, they infiltrated passages, trenches, and shell holes.

“Around me I could see nothing but mud, mud everywhere...”

MAJOR PAUL-HENRI GRAUWIN, IN HIS MEMOIRS, *DOCTOR AT DIEN-BIEN-PHU*, 1955